

Joyous moment: D. Gukesh mobbed by fans after winning the 2024 FIDE Candidates tournament. MICHAŁ WALUSZA

third. By this time, his live rating had plummeted to 2715. Finally, all the hard work with Gajewski started bearing fruit with the hurriedly organised Chennai Grand Masters in December. In this eight-player invitational event, organised to help Gukesh boost his ratings and qualify for the Candidates based on being the highest-rated on the FIDE Circuit, he went on to win the tournament and moved to second on the Circuit. Since topper Caruana had already qualified by coming third in the World Cup, Gukesh got the lone qualifying spot from the FIDE Circuit for the Candidates. What makes Gukesh such a formidable force in world chess is his amazing ability to find the best moves, calculate accurately in quick time, and stay ambitious in search of victory. Unlike his peers, Gukesh did not use computer-aid or engine analysis to find the best continuation. This helped his natural abilities to sense danger and prepare accordingly. Armed with a ticket to the Candidates, Gukesh produced another stellar performance in the Tata Steel Masters in Wijk aan Zee. He punched above his weight to tie for the title and eventually finished second to Chinese Wei Yi following tie-break games.

Significantly, Gukesh bounced back from losing to world champions Liren and Anish Giri in the third and fourth rounds to post a hat-trick of wins, beginning with the conquest of Ian Nepomniachtchi and two Dutchmen, Jorden van Foreest and Max Warmerdam. He continued his campaign without losing any more games. He beat German Alexander Donchenko and Iranian Parham Maghsoodloo. The gain of 18 rating points from this event played its part in Gukesh returning to his best. Gukesh entered the Candidates very well prepared, but without carrying any burden of expectations. Seeded sixth among eight players, Gukesh, at 17, was only the second youngest to play in the Candidates. The record for



the youngest player in the Candidates Tournament stands in the name of the legendary Bobby Fischer, who played as a 16-year-old in 1959. What unfolded at Toronto's The Grand Hall was a story for the ages. Showing great maturity, Gukesh started slowly, was a touch lucky to beat Praggnanandhaa in the second round, and suffered a heartbreak in the seventh round, where he lost to Alireza Firouzja after holding a very promising position.

"I was really disappointed with the way I lost in time pressure. All along, I thought I was winning after a point. After I reached my room and analysed the position, I discovered that, though I felt I was in a winning

position, with correct play, Firouzja could still draw. I made some of the best logical moves, but as computer analysis later suggested, it was not enough for me to win. Then I felt a little better," Gukesh said.

"It was at this point that I felt very good about myself and believed that I could win the Candidates. I went out with Gajewski, along with a Toronto-based friend, who also brought some awesome home-cooked food. Later, we played pickleball, and I really felt good ahead of the second half of the tournament."

Once in the home stretch, Gukesh did not put a foot wrong. He targeted two of the lowest-placed, off-form